



2

At Farmlore in Bengaluru, founder Kaushik Raju remembers a very different market when he began experimenting with experiential dining. In 2019, even pop-ups priced at ₹3,000 attracted criticism for being too expensive.

Raju believes the problem was never entirely affordability. Consumers were comfortable spending ₹10,000 over an evening of food and drinks, but paying a substantial sum upfront for a tasting menu required a different mindset.

"It's not the affordability, it's the mindset that needed to shift," he says.

That shift has become increasingly evident. Farmlore, an intimate 18-seat restaurant centred on ingredients grown on its farm, operates at around 95% occupancy, according to Raju. A 10-course dinner is priced at ₹6,825 plus taxes.

Its clientele has also become considerably more diverse. Younger diners are discovering tasting menus, while older customers are finding value in contemporary interpretations of familiar Indian ingredients. Some guests return regularly, while others save the experience for birthdays and anniversaries.

Raju recalls a woman who travelled from Madhya Pradesh to Bengaluru for her birthday, spent the day in the city, enjoyed a late lunch at Farmlore, and flew home that evening.

A similar phenomenon is playing out near Kasauli, where chef Prateek Sadhu's NAAR has emerged as a destination dining restaurant. Its multi-course tasting menu, priced at ₹6,900 per person excluding taxes, takes diners on a culinary journey through the Himalayas. Add a wine pairing and the experience costs ₹13,400 per person before taxes. Yet, diners are willing to travel considerable distances to experience it.

"In the beginning, it was curiosity more than demand. Kasauli wasn't on anyone's food map," says Sadhu. But as guests began making the journey specifically for the food, word spread.

Today, NAAR attracts guests from cities such as Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Chennai, Hyderabad, and Ludhiana, many of whom plan holidays around their reservations. Some have even made a meal at the restaurant part of their annual getaway.

For Sadhu, the appeal is not simply exclusivity. It is the combination of ingredients, location, storytelling, and a culinary experience that cannot be easily reproduced elsewhere.